

Research Workshop Spring 2026

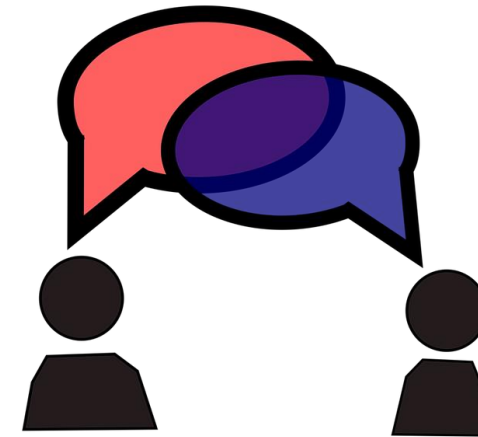
“Writing”

Part 1: Introduction

CEMFI

What do we do?

- *Writing a research paper that others can learn from is no easy task*
- *How should we structure the many, complex details of our research into a coherent whole?*
- **Goal:** a method to build a research paper based on two core ideas
 - Logical **dialogue** between the reader and the writer
 - **Descend** from a higher-level idea to the details of research
- Focus on **structure**, not style



Sources

- **Main:** *The Little Book of Research Writing*, Varanya Chaubey (2018)
- Other books:
 - Economical Writing, Deidre Nansen McCloskey (2019)
 - A Guide for the Young Economist, William Thomson (2001)
- Online
 - Writing Tips for Ph. D. Students (Cochrane)
 - The Ten Most Important Rules of Writing Your Job Market Paper (Goldin and Katz)

Goldin And Katz (10 rules)

Rule #1: *You will probably not have a Nobel Prize winning idea.*

Theorem #1: It is always possible to transform a good idea into a great paper and a superb presentation.

Theorem #2: Even if your idea is Nobel-worthy, you can always make it into a poorly written paper and a lousy presentation. This theorem will probably never be needed; see Rule #1.

Rule #2: *The insights of your paper will first be judged by how you present them.* If your paper is written in an unprofessional manner, your empirical work, mathematical proofs, and models will be viewed with initial skepticism.

Rule #3: *Your paper is an exercise in persuasion* (we mean in positive not normative economics). Your readers are your audience. They have better things to do than read your paper. Make them interested in your thesis and convinced of your argument.

Goldin and Katz (10 rules)

Rule #4: *No great paper—no matter how well constructed, brilliant, and well written—first emerged from the author's printer in that form.* It was rewritten at least 10 times. Rewriting is the true art of writing.

Rule #5: *No author—no matter how careful and humble—can see all (or even most) of his or her writing errors.* Trade papers with another student. Be tough; there will be some initial pain, but gratitude will follow.

Rule #6: *Most paragraphs have too many sentences and most sentences have too many words.* Repetition is boring. We repeat: repetition is boring. Cut, cut, and then cut again.

Goldin and Katz (10 rules)

Rule #7: *The “foot-in-the-door” parts of your written work are the abstract and introduction.* Write them clearly and concisely. The abstract is not simply the first paragraph of your paper (or the last paragraph for that matter). Write them so that they are accessible by any intelligent economist, not just those in your field.

Rule #8: *Verbalizing your argument is more difficult than writing it.* Giving a presentation will reveal where your argument falls flat and will show you how to redraft the paper. Give many presentations before sending out your paper. Give them to a workshop, friends, a dog or cat, even the wall. The presentation will force you to confront inconsistencies in your argument.

Rule #9: *Be your own worst enemy.* If you won't, someone else will.

Goldin and Katz (10 rules)

Rule #10: *There are many other rules.* We cannot cover all of them. A few are:

- All tables and figures must have enough information to allow the reader to figure out how to replicate them, even if the “source” is “see Data Appendix.”
- Tables and figures should be placed *after* the text and not integrated. It is easier to read a working paper if the tabular and graphical material is grouped together.
- Do not use a font that is less than 11 point for text and do not use a font less than 10 point for footnotes and tabular materials. The preferred size is 12 point for text and tables and

Goldin and Katz (10 rules)

11 point for footnotes. If your reader is older than 40 years, you will inflict pain if you use small fonts. A pained reader rarely looks favorably upon the author.

- Use Appendixes for descriptions of data sources, certain proofs, and other matters. For empirical work, make certain that your work can be replicated.
- No one wants to read a “literature review.” It is sophomoric. Integrate the literature with the rest of your paper.
- Do not tell your readers what you will be doing. Just do it.
- Do not use general headings such as: “Model,” “Data,” “Findings,” “Literature Review” (see above). You might as well use 1, 2, 3, and 4. Tell your readers what is in the section, e.g., A Model Demonstrating the Finiteness of the Universe.
- Use meaningful variable names. You may know `ps102`, `plop49`, and `oink34` like the back of your hand, but they do not mean a thing to your reader.
- Do not present every result you have ever produced. Boring. Ask yourself what you need in the presentation and include that. Use an Appendix for other results.
- Check for typos, spelling errors, missing pages, incorrect table or figure numbers, missing references, and the like. These are the cockroaches of writing. Exterminate them.
- Use a style manual or a journal as a guide. Consistency is important.

Cochrane (2005)

Organize the paper in “triangular” or “newspaper” style, not in “joke” or “novel” style. Notice how newspapers start with the most important part, then fill in background later for the readers who kept going and want more details. A good joke or a mystery novel has a long windup to the final punchline. Don’t write papers like that – put the punchline right up front and then slowly explain the joke. Readers don’t stick around to find the punchline in Table 12.

The vast majority of Ph.D. student papers and workshop presentations (not all by students!) get this exactly wrong, and we never really find out what the contribution of the paper is until the last page, the last table, and the last 5 minutes of the seminar.

A good paper is not a travelogue of your search process. We don’t care how you came to figure out the right answer. We don’t care about the hundreds of things you tried that did not work. Save it for your memoirs.

Cochrane (2005)

The introduction should start with what *you do* in this paper, the major contribution. You must *explain* that contribution so that people can understand it. Don't just state your conclusion: "My results show that the pecking-order theory is rejected." Give the *fact* behind that result. "In a regression of x on y , controlling for z , the coefficient is q ."

The first sentence is the hardest. Do not start with philosophy, "Financial economists have long wondered if markets are efficient." Do not start with "The finance literature has long been interested in x ." Your paper must be interesting on its own, and not just because lots of other people wasted space on the subject. Do not start with a long motivation of how important the issue is to public policy. All of this is known to writers as "clearing your throat." It's a waste of space. Start with your central contribution.

Do not start your introduction with a page and a half of other literature. First, your readers are most interested in just figuring out what you do. They can't start wondering if it's better than what others have done until they understand what you do. Second, most readers do not know the literature. It's going to be hard enough to explain your paper in simple terms; good luck explaining everyone else's too.

Cochrane (2005)

Your task now is to *get to the central result as fast as possible*. Most papers do precisely the opposite: They have a long motivation, a long literature review, a big complex model that then gets ignored, descriptive statistics, preliminary results, a side discussion or two and then finally Table 12 of “main estimates.” By then we’re all asleep.

Thus, conclusions should be short and sweet. Do not restate all of your findings. One statement in the abstract, one in the introduction and once more in the body of the text should be enough! You can include a short paragraph or two acknowledging limitations, suggesting implications beyond those in the paper. Keep it short though – don’t write your grant application here outlining all of your plans for future research. And don’t speculate; the reader wants to know your facts not your opinions.

Very nice suggestions, but!

- How do you actually do it?
- Is there a formula to write good papers?
- In this workshop, we will follow one such formula.

Method: Pyramidal Structure of 3 Layers

- **Positioning:** articulate a concise argument about what knowledge the paper contributes
- **Outline:** build an outline to support this argument
- **Paragraphs:** linking the points of the outline

Read Quickly, What did You Learn?

“G fluctuates between 5 and 7 percent. A 1-percent increase in J increases H by 6 percent. In the data, a 1-percent increase in J increases H by close to 12 percent. The correlation between F and K is 0.35. The correlation is expected to be above 0.7. In the data, G is seen to move between 2 and 10 percent.” Chaubey (2018), pg. 13

- Most people will learn very little

Try again

“The fit of the model is weak along three dimensions. First, it does not generate patterns of G observed in the data: it predicts that G fluctuates between 5 and 7 percent, while in the data, G is seen to fluctuate between 2 and 10 percent. Second, H is less responsive to J in the model than in the data: a 1-percent increase in J only increases H by 6 percent, while in the data the number is closer to 12 percent. Third, the correlation between F and K is low at 0.35; typically it is expected to be above 0.7.” Chaubey (2018), pg. 15

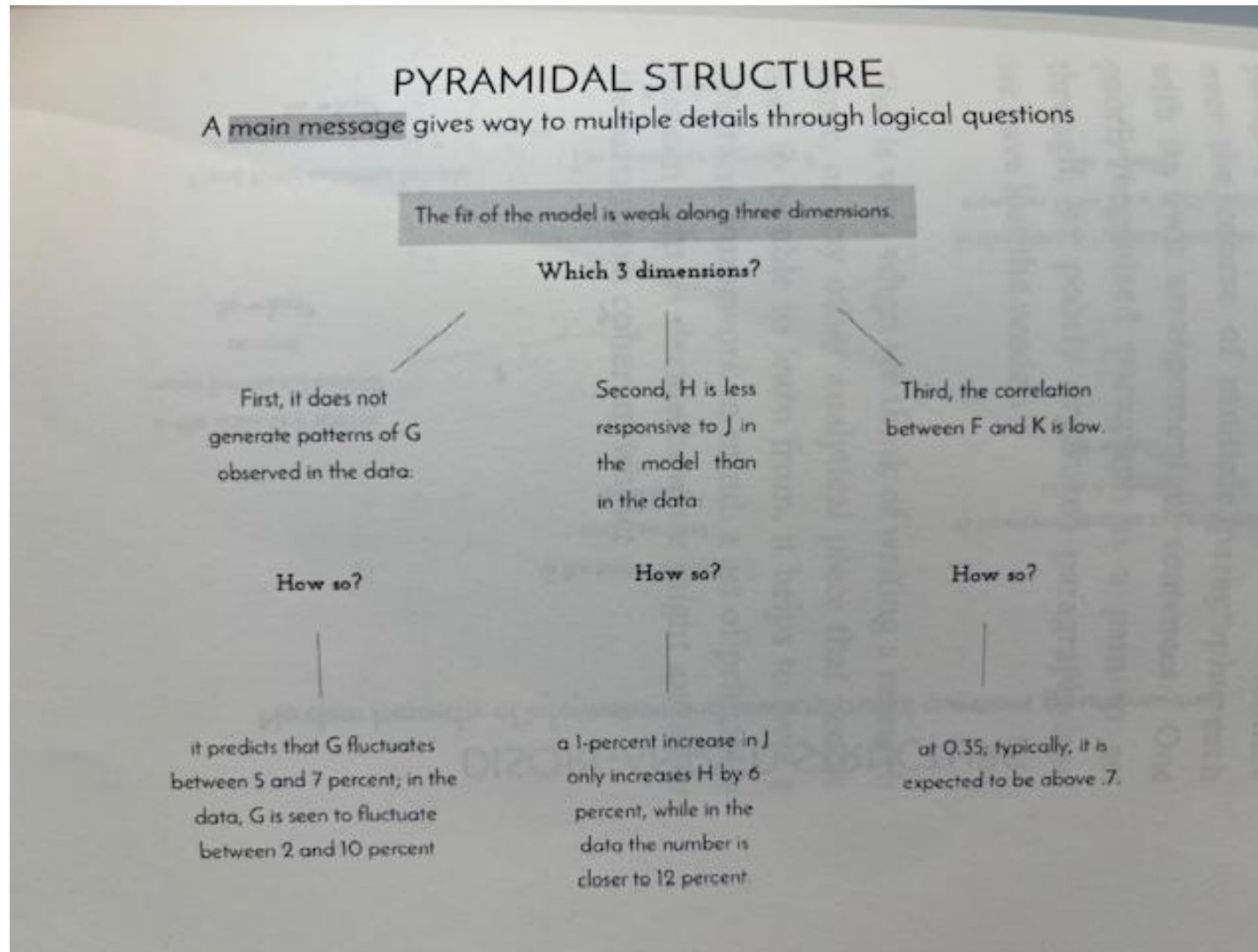
- Why is this better?
- What did help us to **understand** and **remember** the content better (even if you do not know anything about G and H)?

Structure

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- Start with takeaways/main message
- Provoke a question (which three dimensions?)
- Reader can understand what arguments are being assessed

The Importance of Structure



From broad picture to details

- Main Message Up Front (go to details through logical questions)
- The magical number: 7 (+/- 2) items
 - We have a capacity limits to process a lot of information
- Chunk items under meaningful headings
 - E.g., shopping lists
 - As a complex picture: move from broad strokes towards small details

Goal

- **Positioning:** articulate a concise argument about what knowledge the paper contributes
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